their trainees' success or failure. And since failure is not an option, all their energies are concentrated towards ensuring that their students win.

How very different this systematic approach is from the lackadaisical manner in which we try to develop our sportspeople. Selections in India are ad hoc, often dictated by political diktats, or through personal contacts and connections. What India needs today is a firm goal to aspire towards, and what could be more prestigious than aiming for an Olympic gold? Success in the Olympics should be our ambition, but to achieve that end, we need international-level coaching, and for that, I would strongly recommend emulating the Chinese, right from creating a world-class sports infrastructure to spotting and grooming kids with talent. We need to overhaul our selection process and training methodology and choose only the most talented young boys and girls who show promise and have the potential to produce results. Give them professional guidance, use scientific training methods, discipline them if their standards fall, and above all, inspire and motivate them. What needs to be instilled in them right from the beginning is: toil hard to increase efficiency, stamina and strength, be resolute in thought, word and deed, and most important of all, take pride in your performance.

But no sportsperson can achieve results without an equally dedicated and committed coach. Thousands of coaches graduate from the National Institute of Sports (NIS) every year, but what has been their contribution to the development of our sportspeople? Unlike China, they are not held accountable if their trainees do not produce the expected results. The sad truth is that no one questions them, neither the government who employs them, nor the associations who sponsor them, not even their students whose careers depend upon them. As a result, they have grown complacent in their jobs.

A lethargic or apathetic coach can only impede the growth and progress of an athlete. If there were no Gurdev Singh, Ranbir Singh or Dr Howard when I first started running, would I have ever achieved the success I did? No. And I will reiterate what I have always said that it is only the coach who has the power and influence to build a sportsperson's stamina, prowess and self-confidence.

To rid ourselves of this malaise, I would suggest that the government should not employ coaches on a permanent basis, simply because as government employees they have the security, if not job satisfaction, and